

The Emotional Regulation Guide for Children and Teens



**Practical Tools to help kids
manage big feelings & Calm
their bodies**



Dr. Caelan Soma



DR. CAELAN SOMA

I am a clinical psychologist with over 25 years of experience helping families understand and manage emotions and behavior in children and teens. My goal is to make things like child development, managing big feelings and challenging behavior feel less overwhelming for children and their families.

I help families balance warmth with structure. I use simple analogies, visuals, and practical, step-by-step strategies that actually work with real kids.

Over the years, I've written books, created curricula, and trained thousands of professionals on stress, trauma, resilience, and social-emotional development in children and teens. Today, I'm in private practice in Michigan, where I continue the work I love: supporting children and families as they build coping skills, manage anxiety, and feel calmer, more confident, and more connected.

I'm also a mom of two teenage daughters, which keeps me very grounded in what this work looks like outside the therapy room.

Website doctorcae.com

Instagram [@drcaesoma](https://www.instagram.com/drcaesoma)



Dr. Caelan Soma

C O N T E N T S

INTRODUCTION & ABOUT THIS GUIDE

WHAT IS EMOTIONAL REGULATION & WHAT DOES IT LOOK LIKE?

BUILDING EMOTIONAL REGULATION AND CO-REGULATION

EMOTIONAL REGULATION SUPPORTIVE STRATEGIES

INTRODUCTION

Parenting a child who struggles with big emotions and challenging behaviors feel overwhelmed, stressed and second-guessing themselves. Many parents wonder:

What does regulation actually look like?

Why is this so hard for my child?

Am I missing something?

Am I doing something wrong?



This guide is meant to gently shift the question from “What’s wrong with my child?” to “What skills does my child need support building?”



Children are not born knowing how to regulate emotions, manage disappointment and frustration, or control their behavior when they experience fear and worry. These are learned skills that develop over time through supportive relationships, repeated practice, and environments that feel safe enough for mistakes. When children struggle, it is not because they are lazy, defiant, unmotivated, or “too sensitive.” It is because the demands placed on them exceed their current skills. Throughout this guide, you will see consistent themes.

Regulation comes before learning.

Connection comes before correction.

Skills develop through practice, not pressure.

You do not need to be a perfect parent to support your child’s development. What matters most is being a steady presence. Your child needs to feel safe enough to try, fail, and try again. The strategies in this guide are designed to be practical, compassionate, and realistic for everyday family life. You can use them gradually, choosing what works best for your child.



Progress happens in small moments.

This guide will help you be more observant so you can support your child and build both of your regulation skills.

ABOUT THIS GUIDE

This guide is designed for thoughtful parents who want to support their children through connection, not perfection. Begin this guide slowly, select one or two strategies, practice them consistently, and build on them from there. When children learn to ride a bike, we don't expect them to master it immediately. What do we expect and what do we do? We expect that it will take several afternoons of practice for our child to learn to ride their bike independently. We provide training wheels, hold the seat, and run along the side of them until voilà, they are balancing and pedaling all on their own.



Emotional and behavioral regulation develops the same way. Children need repeated opportunities to practice calming their bodies, naming their feelings, and choosing helpful behaviors, with adults providing guidance, modeling, and support throughout.

Skills develop through patience and practice.

When children are taught strategies, structure, and encouragement, regulation and confidence are strengthened.



This guide includes visuals, specific strategies, quick practice tips and scripts for you to use immediately with your child. Reflection prompts are most helpful when used as an opportunity to pause, not as a test. Choose one or two prompts to think about quietly or write down your responses.

The goal isn't to find the "right" answer, but to build awareness of patterns, strengths, stress points, and lessons learned. You can use prompts to identify what is already working, recognize when your child struggles most, and reflect on how your own responses influence outcomes. Revisit the same prompts over time, since insights often change as children grow and skills develop. When used consistently and without self-judgment, reflection prompts will help you move from reacting in the moment to responding intentionally, with confidence and empathy. Remember that you are practicing too.



EMOTIONAL REGULATION

**Emotional
Awareness**



**Manage
rather than
avoid
Emotions**

Practice



WHAT IS EMOTIONAL REGULATION & WHAT DOES IT LOOK LIKE?

Emotional regulation is a child's ability to notice their feelings, manage their body's reactions, and respond in ways that are safe and helpful. It's how kids learn to move from big emotions, like frustration, worry, or excitement back toward calm. This is a skill that develops over time. Children aren't born knowing how to regulate their emotions, they must learn it with support from caring adults.



Emotional regulation doesn't mean kids never get upset.

It looks like:

- Having big feelings without losing control
- Being able to pause before reacting
- Using words, movement, or calming tools instead of hitting, yelling, or shutting down
- Accepting limits and boundaries with support, even when disappointed
- Recovering more quickly after something hard happens

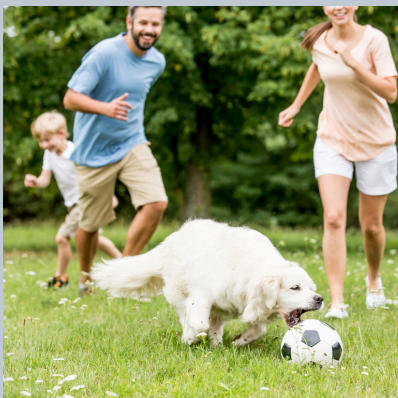


For younger children, regulation might look like needing help to calm their body. For older kids and teens, it looks like beginning to use coping skills on their own such as taking a break, asking for help, or problem-solving instead of exploding.

Why Emotional Regulation Matters

When children can manage emotions and behavior, everyday life gets easier. Interactions at home, at school, and with peers are met with ease. Emotional regulation supports learning, relationships, confidence, and resilience.

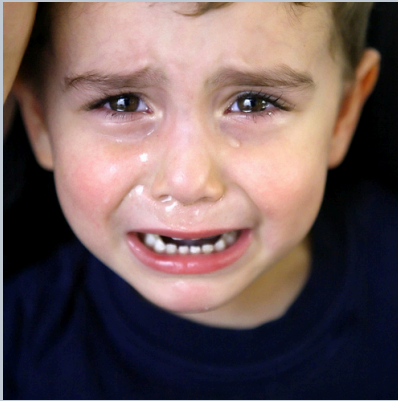
Calm, supportive adults help children learn how to calm themselves over time.



BUILDING EMOTIONAL REGULATION & CO-REGULATION

Big emotions aren't a choice to be "bad". They're a sign that your child's nervous system is overwhelmed and dysregulated. When children are overwhelmed by stress, their brains shift into a stress response, making it difficult to think, listen, or regulate their behavior.

Support and regulation come first; learning and behavior change follow.



You might ask, "Stress? What stress? How does a child who doesn't have to make dinner, pay bills, and work 40 hours every week have stress?" Many everyday experiences can overwhelm a child's nervous system with stress, especially when demands exceed their coping skills. Below is a list of everyday stressors for children. Review these situations to determine whether any of them overwhelm your child.

Common stressors

- Transitions (waking up, leaving the house, changing activities, bedtime)
- Sensory overload (noise, crowds, bright lights, scratchy clothing)
- Fatigue, hunger, or illness
- Academic pressure or fear of making mistakes
- Social stress (feeling left out, conflict with peers, reading social cues)
- Big feelings they don't yet have words for (disappointment, jealousy, grief)
- Feeling rushed, criticized, or misunderstood
- Unexpected changes or lack of predictability



When these stressors accumulate, behavior often reflects a sense of overwhelm and signals a need for support, structure, and regulation. Behavior reflects **stress**.

Many children hold it together all day and release emotions at home because this is where they feel safe. .





Co-Regulation

Before children can regulate themselves, they need co-regulation from caring adults. Co-regulation means you calm down **with** your child. Children must borrow a parent's nervous system and the strategies they use to remain balanced until they can do so independently. Imagine a mother koala bear with a new baby, called a joey. A joey lives in the mother koala's pouch for the first 6 months of life. The baby koala is entirely dependent on the parent for safety, warmth, and nutrition. Then, for the next several months, they move from the pouch and stay on their mother's back. When the joey feels scared, wobbly, or unsure, the mother koala's steady presence and gentle support help the joey feel secure. During this period, the joey learns skills such as climbing and foraging until it can move, balance, and explore with confidence.

Co-regulation works in the same way. Children (or anyone feeling overwhelmed) need a calm presence to help regulate their emotions. Any adult can act like the parent koala: offering steady support, reassurance, and guidance, without taking over or removing the child's opportunity to practice self-regulation. The goal is to help the child internalize these skills, much like the baby koala eventually learns to move independently.

Emotional regulation doesn't depend on age as much as it depends on experience and support. Some children, no matter how old they are, need a lot of help calming their bodies and emotions, while others may need very little.

What matters most is meeting your child where they are right now. Co-regulation is not a sign of weakness or "babying", it's how children learn the skills they'll eventually use on their own. When adults stay calm, set steady limits, and offer support, children are practicing regulation in real time. It's common for parents to think an older child "should be able to handle this." But many children haven't been taught these skills yet—or haven't had enough practice using them when emotions run high. With consistent support and guidance, those skills grow, and over time children move from needing co-regulation to being able to regulate independently.

Emotional Regulation Supportive Strategies

01

NAME AND NORMALIZE
EMOTIONS

02

MATCH EMOTIONS TO
BODY SENSATIONS

03

TEACH AND PRACTICE
REGULATION SKILLS
WHEN CALM

04

CO-REGULATE BEFORE
EXPECTING SELF-
REGULATION

05

SEPARATE YOUR CHILD
FROM THEIR BEHAVIOR

NAME AND NORMALIZE EMOTIONS

Children (and adults!) often feel emotions intensely but don't have the words to describe them.

Naming the emotion bridges that gap.

Saying something as simple as, "It looks like you're feeling frustrated because these math problems are tricky," is helpful.

Just hearing you label an emotion can help calm your child's nervous system. It signals to them that you see that they are uncomfortable and that what they are feeling is valid.

Over time, children learn to recognize their emotions. Once a feeling is named, it becomes easier to decide what to do next.



PRACTICE TIPS & SCRIPTS

OBSERVE

**LOOK AT YOUR CHILD'S BODY
LANGUAGE AND FACIAL
EXPRESSIONS.**

**LISTEN TO THEIR TONE OF
VOICE.**

LABEL & VALIDATE

AVOID JUDGMENT.

**"YOU SEEM SAD."
"THAT LOOKS FRUSTRATING."
"IT'S OKAY TO FEEL NERVOUS
ABOUT THE SOCCER TRYOUT."**

CO-REGULATE

**STAY PRESENT.
MODEL CALM.
GUIDE YOUR CHILD TOWARD
REGULATION.**



What is my body telling me?
Our body gives us signals before emotions explode.
Notice the signal first—then choose the skill.

Body is Too Fast / Amped Up

Fast heartbeat
Tight chest or clenched jaw
Hot face, sweaty hands
Yelling, pacing, fidgeting
Feeling out of control

What helps: Slow the body down
Slow breathing (long exhales), Cold water on face or hands
Wall push-ups or heavy work, Slow stretching or yoga
Calm music, Firm hugs or squeezing a pillow

Body is Too Slow / Shut Down

Heavy body, slumped posture
Quiet voice or "I don't care"
Wanting to hide or be alone
Low energy or numbness
Stomach aches or headaches

What helps: Gently wake the body up
Movement (jumping, walking, dancing), Warmth (blanket, warm drink)
Music with a beat, Rocking, swinging, rhythmic play
Strong sensory input (smells, textures), Playful connection or humor



MATCH EMOTIONS TO BODY SENSATIONS

When we feel big emotions, our bodies often give us clues.

Our stomachs might feel tight, our hearts might beat fast,
or our hands might sweat.

Bring attention to both the emotion and your child's body.

This helps them recognize feelings early, enabling them to
regulate before the feeling becomes too intense.



PRACTICE TIPS & SCRIPTS

PAUSE & NOTICE

**“WHERE DO YOU NOTICE THAT
FEELING IN YOUR BODY?”**

NAME IT

**“THAT TIGHT SENSATION IN
YOUR CHEST SOUNDS LIKE
WORRY.”**

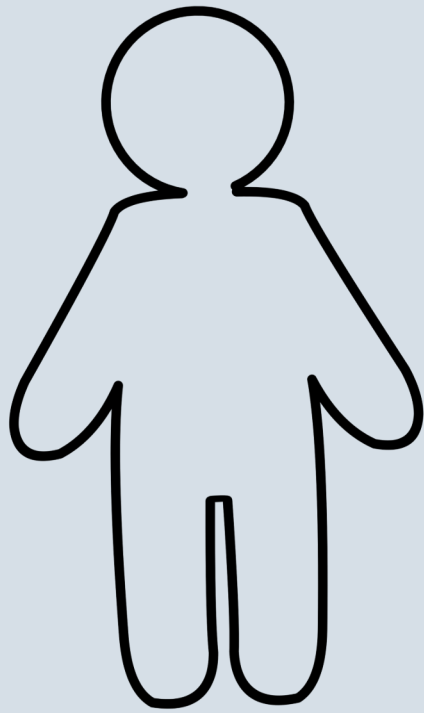
REFLECT

**“WHEN YOUR BODY
EXPERIENCES WORRY, THE
TIGHTNESS IS THE MESSAGE IT
SENDS YOU.”**



Matching Emotions to Body Sensations

Emotion	Common Body Sensation	Nervous System State
Anxiety/Fear	Heart racing, cold hands, “butterflies”, shallow breath	Flight
Anger Frustration	Hot face, clenched jaw, tight chest, “buzzing” skin	Fight
Sadness Loneliness	Heavy arms/legs, lump in throat, watery eyes, tired	Freeze
Excitement Joy	Wiggling, light feeling in chest, bubbles in stomach	Safe & Social
Overwhelm	dizzy, ringing in ears, feeling outside of the body	Shutdown



TEACH REGULATION SKILLS DURING CALM TIMES

Children cannot learn new skills when they are dysregulated.

Practice these strategies when your child is relaxed.

When your child becomes overwhelmed, remind them of the strategy.



PRACTICE TIPS & SCRIPTS

BREATHING SKILLS

**“TAKE SLOW BREATHS IN
THROUGH YOUR NOSE, OUT
THROUGH YOUR MOUTH.”**

REPEAT.

GROUNDING

**“NOTICE YOUR BODY.
TOUCH YOUR HANDS TO YOUR
LAP AND FEEL YOUR FEET ON
THE FLOOR.”**

**“NOTICE YOUR HEARTBEAT BY
PLACING ONE HAND ON YOUR
CHEST.”**

SOOTHING SELF-TALK

“I CAN DO HARD THINGS”

**“I’M LEARNING TO CALM
DOWN.”**



CO-REGULATE BEFORE EXPECTING SELF- REGULATION

Co-regulation is when your child feels you before they hear you.

If you escalate, they will escalate.

If you stay steady, your child's system will sync to yours.

Co-regulation is not giving in, letting bad behavior slide, Or avoiding limits.

Co-regulation is meeting your child's nervous system first, creating conditions for learning, and making connections possible.



PRACTICE TIPS & SCRIPTS

WHAT TO SAY

“I’M HERE.”
“YOU’RE SAFE.”
“THIS IS HARD.”
“WE’LL FIGURE IT OUT.”

WHAT TO DO

SIT NEARBY
GET ON YOUR CHILD’S LEVEL
KEEP YOUR BODY RELAXED
BREATHE SLOWLY

AVOID

LECTURES
IMMEDIATE CONSEQUENCES
TOO MANY WORDS





A regulated adult
can calm a
dysregulated
child. A
dysregulated
adult cannot.

SEPARATE YOUR CHILD FROM THEIR BEHAVIOR

Address what a child did, not who they are.

Children learn best when feedback is specific, calm, and focused on skill-building rather than shame. The goal is learning and repairing. Ultimately, you want to help your child understand the impact of their behavior and practice better choices rather than punishing them.

When you keep behavior separate, it protects a child's sense of self while still holding clear boundaries.



PRACTICE TIPS & SCRIPTS

WHAT TO SAY

“THAT CHOICE WASN’T SAFE.”

**“LET’S TALK WHEN YOU ARE
CALM ABOUT WHAT YOU CAN
DO NEXT TIME.”**

WHAT TO SAY

**“DO YOU WANT TO TRY
RESPONDING AGAIN?”**

**“LET’S PRACTICE A DIFFERENT
WAY TO HANDLE THIS.”**

DO NOT SAY

“YOU’RE BEING BAD.”

“WHAT’S WRONG WITH YOU?”

“YOU’RE SO DISRESPECTFUL.”

**“WHY CAN’T YOU EVER
BEHAVE?”**



Parent Reflection

Emotional Regulation - Notes

Date

What situations tend to overwhelm my child the most?
How does my child typically show stress or big emotions?

What emotions are hardest for me to stay calm with?
What helps me regulate when things feel intense?

How comfortable am I sitting with my child's discomfort without trying to fix it right away?

What is one small shift I could try to better support regulation this week?



Client *Testimonials*



“What stood out most was how practical and compassionate this approach felt. We weren’t blamed, we were guided. Our child now has language for what’s happening in their body, and meltdowns don’t last as long or feel as scary anymore.”

Jackson’s Dad



“As parents, we were stuck between wanting to be supportive and needing to hold boundaries. This approach showed us we don’t have to choose one or the other. We learned how to regulate first, then problem-solve. Our child is more confident, and we’re no longer walking on eggshells.”

Sophia’s parents



“Learning to support regulation instead of trying to ‘fix’ emotions changed everything. Our child feels safer, recovers faster, and trusts us more. I am a lot less overwhelmed.”

Parent of Jasper

Want more support?

Online Course for Parents

When big feelings take over: A body based approach to help kids regulate emotions by listening to their body



Dr. Caelan Soma

A Note for Parents: This guide is meant to be a supportive tool to help you navigate your parenting journey with confidence. While the strategies shared here are based on research in child development and my work as a clinical psychologist with children and families, they are not a replacement for professional therapy or clinical consultation. Every child and family is unique; please use your best judgment and consult with a specialist if you have specific concerns about your child's development or well-being.



Dr. Caelan Soma



Dr. Caelan Soma

The Emotional Regulation Guide for is a practical, relationship-based guide for parents who want calm, respectful and emotionally intelligent strategies to help support their child.

Structure - Skills - Strategies